

journey from design to deployment, tend to stand out. Strong grounding in computer architecture, combined with a portfolio of practical, hands-on work carries more weight than coursework alone.

Are there hot domains where demand is currently surging?

Yes, demand is rising in AI, IoT, semiconductor design, and embedded systems. However, what makes candidates particularly valuable is flexibility, the ability to apply skills across shifting domains, whether in medical devices or emerging AI hardware.

What experiences and mindset best prepare candidates for startup success?

Internships should be immersive, outcome-driven, and ideally last at least a year, ending in a tangible deliverable. What matters is not the label but the depth of engagement and contribution to a project's success. From our perspective, resilience and a willingness to constantly learn are paramount. Startup roles are deeply unstructured; the best engineers volunteer for discomfort, hop domains, and thrive in a culture "where everyone does everything." Comfort with ambiguity, eagerness to cross traditional boundaries, and a hunger for continuous growth are indispensable traits.

How do startup compensation and incentives compare to those at large corporations?

It's a misconception that startups universally pay less. For key roles and skill sets, compensation often matches or even exceeds corporate standards and remains highly flexible. Beyond salary, high performers may earn bonuses, stock options (typically vesting over several years), and access to rapid career growth, which is often far faster than what large companies offer. Unique incentives include educational partnerships, such as pursuing an

IIT Madras degree while working, continuous learning opportunities, and stock-based rewards designed to strike a balance between growth and well-being. For many, the chance to have a meaningful stake and tangible impact from the start is a major attraction rarely found in corporates.

How do career paths in startups differ fundamentally from corporate roles?

Startups offer steeper learning curves and earlier exposure to diverse challenges, including customer-facing roles, often within three years. Salary growth may start modestly, but responsibility, skills, and equity potential increase much faster than in the rigid, siloed pathways typical of large organisations.

How are skill requirements evolving, and what's being done to bridge the industry-academia gap?

The greatest challenge in the coming years will be hiring for cultural fit and adaptability rather than purely technical proficiency. As the Indian government and academia increase investment in R&D, technical gaps are expected to shrink, placing greater emphasis on mindset and learning agility. Collaborations with academia, particularly through partnerships with IIT Madras and immersive student internships, are vital for aligning skill supply with industry demand and ensuring continued relevance in hiring.

Why computer vision chips, and how does Mindgrove differ from global rivals?

With backgrounds in both electronics and computer vision, we recognised early the limitations of imported chips in India—they are either stripped down (camera-only) or overkill (expensive, high-end processors). Mindgrove's innovation lies in creating a middle ground: affordable chips that tightly integrate camera input and processing, tailored for Indian conditions. By

excluding costly AI accelerators, we keep products accessible and relevant to local needs, particularly in fast-growing sectors such as smart manufacturing and automation. Our Shakti processor journey, born from academic collaboration, reflects the power of working hand in hand with institutions to drive frontier innovation.

How are you building credibility for Indian-designed chips against global giants?

Earning trust is a long-term process, built on proof of concept, sustained commitment, and consistent problem-solving for customers, not on marketing gloss.

How do price and value compare with international options, and how do startups like yours drive Indian semiconductor self-reliance?

For low-volume launches, pricing is often on par with international options, while scaling brings cost advantages. ROI varies by focus, differentiation may come from certifications, features, or partnership value. However, the most crucial lever for national progress is IP ownership. By developing and retaining domestic chip IP, we enable genuine value addition and advance India's strategic independence.

What advice would you offer those starting in India's semiconductor space?

The tools, knowledge, and support systems are now firmly in place to make a real leap into chip design and entrepreneurship in India. The journey is demanding, but for those who begin now, the rewards are immense, and the opportunity to shape the industry is unprecedented. **EFY**

This interview is an excerpt of a longer discussion. For the full transcript, please visit: <https://efy.co.in/int3Dec25>

